



Inside story: Collagen is the structural scaffolding for the skin, bones, tendons, ligaments, cartilage, and even gut lining. It's like the internal glue that keeps your body resilient and springy — the kind of resilience every athlete needs. GETTY IMAGES

- ✦ Faster injury rehabilitation
- ✦ Less joint stiffness after heavy lifting or long runs
- ✦ Improved skin quality, especially in endurance athletes exposed to oxidative stress
- ✦ Better gut health, especially when collagen replaces whey for those with intolerance

One elite female swimmer in her late 30s told me, "Whey helped my muscles, but collagen saved my shoulders."

Another pro cricketer said his chronic elbow pain reduced in just three weeks after switching to a collagen-Vitamin C routine post-training.

Tips on how to use collagen

If you're ready to make the switch or even pair it with your current whey, here's what I recommend:

✦ **Dosage:** 10 to 15 grams of hydrolysed marine or bovine collagen peptides daily is optimal for most athletes.

✦ **Timing:** The best time to take collagen is 30 to 60 minutes before a

workout, especially when combined with Vitamin C to enhance absorption and tissue targeting.

✦ **Form:** Look for flavourless, odourless collagen peptides that mix easily into your black coffee, smoothie, or even *parathas* and *idlis*.

✦ **Stacking:** You can still take whey post-workout for muscle synthesis, but take collagen earlier in the day to support joint, tendon, and skin repair.

Marine vs Bovine: What's best?

I recommend marine collagen for most athletes because it's Type I dominant — the type most prevalent in skin, tendons, and bones. It also has superior bioavailability, meaning your body absorbs it more efficiently. It's ideal for those who want clean, heavy-metal-tested, sustainable options. Bovine collagen, known for its Type I and III collagen content, offers excellent support for skin and gut health. However, due to religious preferences in India, many individuals may choose to avoid bovine sources and opt for marine instead. Clean sourcing, no additives,

and third-party testing are non-negotiable.

The biggest myth is that collagen is only for glowing skin. That's like saying protein is only for bodybuilders. As a performance nutritionist, my job is to help athletes last longer, heal faster, and age better. Collagen helps regenerate soft tissue, protect your joints, and even reduce inflammation through glycine pathways. In a world where ACL tears, shoulder impingements, and overuse injuries can end dreams, collagen is not a beauty supplement. It's a biomechanical insurance policy.

Collagen isn't a trend — it's a return to what your body needs, but modern diets lack. It's not a competitor to whey — it's the missing counterpart.

If you're an athlete or an everyday warrior who wants to train smarter, heal better, and age powerfully, start thinking beyond biceps. Start thinking about fascia, ligaments, cartilage, and recovery.

Collagen is not optional anymore — it's essential.